UBS

Latest update
18 March 2015

Sounds good

Tone of voice for UBS

All examples we use here are genuine pieces of UBS writing.
The rewrites are just suggestions. (And Legal and Compliance have checked them.)

Internal access:
goto/bdp

External access:
www.ubs.com/brand-design-platform

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Writing matters

There's a lot riding on our writing.

People experience us in different ways: events, meetings, presentations and pitches. But mostly, people experience us through the words we write: bids, brochures, intranet articles, tweets, LinkedIn profiles, employee messages, invitations, letters, emails. Every time we write, we have a chance to shape what readers think of us. A chance to make them feel interested in, and positive about, working with us or for us.

This guide will help you do that, wherever you're based, whether you're writing for clients or colleagues and whether or not you have writing in your job description. We all use words, so we can all use guidance. (I know I can.)

Take a look at this:
Individuals around the world look to UBS to provide them with the advice, expertise and opportunities they need to protect and grow their wealth.

Now this:
Keep your wealth safe – and see it grow. You'll get the advice and opportunities you need, whether you're in Basel, Brussels or Beijing.

They say the same thing. But they sound different. And I know which I'd rather read.

We want to sound more like the second. It gets across the essence of who we are, what we're like and what makes us different. And it brings our personality to life and makes us easy to relate to. That, in turn, will help bring us success.

Keep reading to see how your writing can play a part in that.



Hubertus Kuelps
Group Head Communications and Branding

In short

The basics

From brand to words

We want people to feel we're:
- Optimistic by nature
- Purposefully intelligent
- Confidently human

That's our brand personality. As writers, our job is to bring it to life. How? By always thinking from our reader's point of view. Will they understand what we've written, feel we're credible and want to come back for more? To help make sure they do our writing is:

Clear
Convincing
…with Charm

	Optimistic by nature	Purposefully intelligent	Confidently human
We need to	Be smart, show empathy		
By making readers think	I understand it	I believe it	I like it
So our language is	Clear Simple, concise, understandable. Easy to understand first time.	Convincing Relevant, believable, confident. In control of our subject. In tune with what readers are interested in.	…with Charm Readable, likeable, memorable. Distinctive through personality. We keep readers reading (and not just because they have to).
And that's	Good writing	Good marketing and communications	Differentiating

In a nutshell

We want readers to think	I understand it	I believe it	I like it
So our language is	Clear	Convincing	…with Charm
Here's how	Keep it simple: Five words instead of ten. Put the main point first: Start with what matters most Use subheadings and bullet points: Structured, easy to skim Write like you speak: Use everyday words and phrases Use active verbs: Clearer and more human	Only say what you need to: Focus on the essentials Benefits before processes: What's important for readers, not how we got there Concrete not abstract: Say what you mean, avoid jargon Evidence not adjectives: Use facts to make readers believe Only claim what you can prove: Make Legal and Compliance happy too	Be personal: Talk about *we*, *u*s and *you* Vary the rhythm: Mix long and short sentences Make observations that resonate: Include truths everyone can relate to Ask questions: (including 'what if?'): Draw readers in Paint pictures: Help them imagine what you're describing Use the occasional aside: (But with a light touch.)

Find what you need

These guidelines are for everyone

They explain our tone of voice, with techniques and tips to help you master it. You'll also find:
- examples of our writing rewritten in the tone of voice, with a guide to what's changed
- a checklist to help keep you on the right track.

Use different sections depending on what you do and what you're trying to achieve.

You	need a quick guide to our tone of voice	write every day as your main job	check other people's writing	want to encourage colleagues to change the way they write	use writing to help you do your job
Find it here	In short, pp. 4–7	In short, pp. 4–7	In short, pp. 4–7	In short, pp. 4–7	In short, pp. 4–7
		In detail, pp. 8–28	Checklist, p. 44	Bringing it all together, pp. 29–43	Checklist, p. 44
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For advice on UBS terminology, and style rules covering everything from dates and job titles to hyphens and colons, see our *Language guidelines for written English at UBS.*

In detail

Working with words

Clear

Clarity is the foundation of good writing. Readers have less time and shorter attention spans than ever. So be concise. And organize your writing to help them find their way around.

- Put the main point first. And dive straight in.
- Keep it simple.
- Use everyday language.
- Avoid long sentences or paragraphs.
- Use subheadings and bullet points.
- Use active verbs.

Try this
If you're using a few sentences to say just one thing, the chances are there's a simpler way. So imagine you're explaining it to someone, and start with 'which basically means that...'. Now try writing it like that.

Keep it simple

So this:

Tax information is provided based upon our understanding of current tax legislation and applicable rates. These may change in the future and they may not apply to your individual circumstances. Please be aware that UBS does not give tax advice and you should therefore consult your own legal and tax advisors, as you deem necessary, before entering into any investment.

Becomes this:

Remember to check whether investments are suitable from a tax point of view. We've given you information based on current laws and rates, but we can't advise you on this. So talk to your legal or tax advisor to make sure.

Clear

Put the main point first. And dive straight in.

What does your reader need to know, feel or do? Remember to think about it from their point of view, not just ours. Here's an example:

Know	*My fees are changing*
Feel	*Everything's under control*
Do	*Get in touch now*

Then start with the most important thing. Don't bury it halfway down or feel you have to build up to it.

If a client has to sign a form, tell them that first. Then add some background information if you need to.

So this:

Dear Mr. Smith,

As of 1 January 2014, the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) strictly prohibits the promotion of Non Mainstream Pooled Investments (NMPI) to retail investors, unless an exception applies.

Becomes this:

Dear Mr. Smith,

If you'd like to invest in Non-Mainstream Pooled Investments, please sign the form we've sent you to confirm you understand the features and risks.

This is because, from January 2014, it will be against Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) rules to promote Non-Mainstream Pooled Investments (NMPI) to retail investors.

Try this
Cut your first sentence. Does what you've written still work? If it does, you've taken too long to get to the point.

Clear

Avoid long sentences or paragraphs

Long sentences are hard to follow. And long paragraphs make writing look uninviting. Keep your sentences under 30 words (but don't always hit that max). And stick to one topic per paragraph.

So this:

In the event that you have a complaint concerning harassment, wish to report an incident or learn that conduct of the nature prohibited by the UBS Anti-Harassment and Non-Discrimination policy may be occurring, you must immediately report the matter to your supervisor, your next level manager or a Human Resources Advisor.

This is one sentence with 51 words in it.

Becomes this:

If you're being harassed, report it to your supervisor, next level manager or HR right away. You should also do this if you find out that someone isn't complying with our 'Anti-harassment and non-discrimination policy'.

It's now two sentences. The first has 16 words, the second has 19 words.

Clear

Use subheadings and bullet points

A clear structure makes it easy for your reader to find their way around and get the message quickly. Use subheadings as signposts for the reader and help them skim read.

Use subheadings as:

Labels	*Our view in short*
Summaries	*We think equities will outperform bonds*
or	
Attention-grabbers	*Feeling cautious?*

Use the same sort all the way through the same piece of writing. Don't mix labels and attention-grabbers, for instance. Before you start writing, get your key points down in the order you want to say them. Then use them to write your subheadings.

Bullet points make writing easier to digest by:
- introducing structure up front
- breaking up long paragraphs
- setting out steps, options and checklists

Use a consistent style. Start all the bullets with verbs or make them all questions, for example. Or use full sentences. But don't mix different styles in one list. And don't use too many. If you have more than five, group them under separate headings.

If they're full sentences, start each with a capital letter and end it with a period. Otherwise, start each with a lower case letter.

Try this
Hold the piece of writing out in front of you, so you can't read the body copy. Is the structure still clear from the subheadings?

Clear

So this:

The Bahamas, historically enjoying political stability, offer a well-developed and sophisticated banking and trust environment with more than 250 well-respected and licensed banks and trust companies. Its excellent location, only 185 miles from Miami and sharing the same time zone as the New York Stock Exchange and many Latin American countries, situates well for any international investment business.

Becomes this:

The Bahamas have a sophisticated banking and trust industry. They're also:

- politically stable
- home to more than 250 licensed (and respected) banks and trust companies
- just 185 miles from Miami
- in the same time zone as the New York Stock Exchange

Clear

Use everyday words and phrases

Use words you'd say if you were talking to your reader face-to-face. Formal language makes things complex and puts distance between you and your reader. Use everyday language to sound more human. You won't be dumbing down your message.

In fact, you'll sound smarter as you'll show you're in control of your subject. You'll be making yourself easier to understand – even to colleagues or clients.

So this:

As a consequence of your classification as an Elective Professional you will lose the specific protections afforded to Private Clients in respect of NMPIs.

Becomes this:

Because you're now classified as an Elective Professional, when it comes to NMPIs you won't get the same protection as Private Clients.

Instead of	Try
Additional	Extra/more
Allow	Let
Assist	Help
Disregard	Ignore
Due to	Because
Ensure	Make sure
Following	After
However	But
Improved	Better
In order to	To
Please note	Remember
Purchase	Buy
Prior to	Before
Provide	Give
Regarding	About
Require	Need
Such as	Including/like
Therefore	So
Utilise	Use

Try this
Read what you've written out loud. Does it sound like how you'd say it? If it doesn't, the writing's too formal. If you're running out of breath, the sentences are too long. If you're stumbling, so will your reader.

Clear

Use active verbs

Another thing to avoid is passive verbs. They make us sound cold and bureaucratic. And they hide who, or what, is doing something.

Like this:

The rates will be calculated on an annual basis.

Make the verb active to sound clearer, like this:

We'll calculate the rates each year.

And if you're giving bad news, passive verbs like *mistakes were made* sound like you're avoiding responsibility. Better to say:

We made a mistake.

Contractions are another way to make your writing sound more everyday. So *we will*, *we have* and *you will* become *we'll*, *we've* and *you'll*, for example. But take care, as some contractions can sound strange, like *it'd*, *what'll* and *could've*.

Convincing

Being convincing is the basis of good communication. Make sure your readers believe what you're saying as well as understand it. Write in a way that's relevant, confident and credible.

- Only say what you need to
- Benefits before processes
- Concrete, not abstract
- Evidence, not adjectives
- Only claim what you can prove

Only say what you need to
What's your main message? Everything you write should help get that message across. If it doesn't, cut it.

Here's a client letter:

Dear Mrs. Smith

UBS Property Financing – for your most complex needs, a flexible solution

Thank you for choosing UBS Property Financing. This letter contains details of your new mortgage, including your account number and start and end dates, and also outlines the different ways you can choose to make repayments.

UBS Property Financing is designed specifically for our clients and is exclusively available in the UK. Drawing on our understanding of your requirements and the specialist expertise within UBS Wealth Management, we have created a mortgage that is entirely built around you.

The client's already signed up, so the letter doesn't need the highlighted parts.

Convincing

Benefits before processes

What does your reader care about? What's in it for them? Start with that.

It's a two-step process:

1. Think of something we do: provide accurate reporting. What does it mean for clients? There could be *functional* and *emotional* benefits. Start with the functional:

   Reliable information.

2. To find the emotional benefit, ask what that means for clients:

   Being able to make investment decisions that feel right.

Try this
Ask "so what?" and keep asking it until you get to the benefit.

So this:

We provide accurate reporting.



Becomes this:

You'll be able to make decisions that feel right, because our reporting is accurate.

Your main point helps you decide what the most important benefits are, if there's more than one.
So here, if you're writing about using our records to fill in a tax return, you'd say:

Be confident you've filled in your tax form right by using our data.

Convincing

Concrete, not abstract

Concrete phrases mean more than abstract ideas. For example, instead of *integrated bank* say *all our teams work together*.

Jargon or technical language can sound abstract. Will your reader know what you mean? Colleagues, peers and sophisticated clients might. But mostly that won't be the case. So use an everyday term instead. Or if you really can't avoid using jargon (and sometimes you can't), explain it.

So this:

You receive personalized and adjustable portfolio proposals

Our open architecture approach means you will be offered the most suitable instruments and products to achieve your goals, not only from UBS, but also from other carefully selected top providers.

Becomes this:

You'll get personal portfolio proposals that can change with your needs

You'll be able to choose products from us and other providers who we hand-pick.

Convincing

Evidence, not adjectives

Which are you more likely to believe? *We offer a responsive service* or *we answer your calls 24 hours a day, every day?* It's more convincing to give readers evidence rather than just unsupported adjectives. Readers need a reason to believe adjectives like:

transparent
robust
comprehensive
helpful
easy

Have a look at this:

At UBS, our response to the challenges our clients face is to offer a *unique new* investment process that builds on and extends our impressive existing capabilities.

What makes the investment process unique? That's far more likely to stick in readers' minds. What makes our capabilities impressive? Give an example. Readers will make up their own minds.

Try this
Use the as-opposed-to test. Every time you find an adjective, imagine your reader saying *as opposed to what?* If the answer is ridiculous, you can do without the adjective.

Convincing

Only claim what you can prove

If you *are* going to use an adjective, make sure it's accurate.

Be extra careful with words like this (or expect a call from Legal and Compliance):

global
leading
perfect
superior
total
unique

And be careful about promising things that aren't definite. It might be better to say *we can* do something, rather than *we will,* when you're talking about something we can't guarantee.

…with Charm

See the difference

Our service
Your client advisor will use a structured advisory approach to understand your situation, find the appropriate investment solution based on your personal preferences, and determine how to make best use of our offering.

We can make this clearer and more convincing.

Achieving your plans
Your client advisor will get to know your aims. Then they'll find the right investments for you and make sure you make the most of what we can offer.

But we can do even more, to sound human and show our personality.
By adding more charm.

What's in it for you?
A client advisor who'll get to know you, to understand where you are now and where you want to be. They'll pick the investments to take you there. And work out what else we can do for you. (So you don't miss out.)

…with Charm

This is how we differentiate ourselves, by keeping readers interested.

There are two main techniques you can use all the time to add a little charm to your writing. Then there are others to use whenever you can, to really show we're confidently human and optimistic by nature.

The main techniques:
- use personal pronouns
- vary the rhythm

Use personal pronouns
Use *we*, *us* and *you*. Sometimes we say *UBS* or *the bank*, and talk about *clients*. Using personal pronouns helps us sound more human. Try to imagine a real person when you're writing – a friend or a relative, rather than your boss. You'll find you write more naturally. Sometimes you'll need to add *as our client* the first time you mention *you*. This will be if you're writing about something people will only get if we take them on as a client.

Vary the rhythm
Vary the length of your sentences. Lots of short sentences sound robotic and unfriendly. Writing made up of only long sentences is monotonous and saps concentration. So be more interesting. Mix short and longer sentences (though still 20–30 words max). And use the occasional very short one to inject some rhythm.

To go beyond these two techniques, add more charm by being:

Memorable
- make observations that resonate
- paint pictures
- use metaphors

Intriguing
- ask questions, including *what if?*
- use the occasional aside

…with Charm

Be memorable

Make observations that resonate
Think about the bigger picture and how the things you're writing about fit in to your reader's life.

So this:	Becomes this:
UBS offers innovative programs that enable employees to structure their working hours according to their individual needs and taking into account operational requirements.	Nine to five's not for everyone. If your job doesn't have to fit in those hours, we can talk about a different working day for you.

Paint pictures
This can help you bring benefits to life. Help your reader imagine what you're writing about.

So this:	Becomes this:
Our interactive tools enable short-, medium- and long-term analysis of movements in everything from currencies and stocks to global indices.	Use our online tools to analyze how the markets are doing. From your desk, from the taxi (or your garden).

Use metaphors
Use familiar things to help explain technical points or make a point more vivid. Like this, from one of our research reports:

In the war against the recession, the European Central Bank has hardly been the boldest of generals.

…with Charm

Be intriguing

Ask questions
What gets you interested when you're reading? Questions draw readers in. They also work well as subheadings.

So this:

As a UBS client, you can subscribe to receive the CIO Monthly Letter on the CIO Portal of UBS e-banking or via your client advisor.

Becomes this:

Want to get the CIO Monthly Letter? Use the CIO Portal or ask your client advisor.

Or, even better, think about the benefit:

Want to keep up to speed with the markets? Use the CIO Portal or ask your client advisor about getting our monthly letter.

To really set your reader thinking, try asking *what if?*

So this:

While many programs charge you 90,000 points for an airline ticket worth up to $900, with My Choice Rewards that same ticket is only 50,000 points, saving you up to 40,000 points. Or redeem just 25,000 points for a ticket worth up to $350.

Becomes this:

What if you could fly away sooner, rather than later? With My Choice Rewards a $900 airline ticket is just 50,000 points, compared to the 90,000 that other credit card reward programs charge.

…with Charm

Use the occasional aside
An aside is a kind of gentle wit – a disarming way of showing the reader our intelligence, with a light touch. It's a few words in brackets to show readers that we understand what life is like and that we can see it their way. But don't take this as a green light to put long passages in brackets because sometimes they make things harder to follow.

Here's an example:

You decide whether members of your family or a professional will manage the fund. And they'll base their investment decisions on guidelines you've agreed. (We'll leave that part to you.)

But be careful. Use asides sparingly. More than one or two in every 400 words risks overdoing the effect and sounding forced. You'll probably only use one in any single piece of writing.

…with Charm

How much charm?
How you use these techniques depends on why you're writing and who for. Use them more if you want to be distinctive and persuasive and to get a reaction. You won't need to go so far if you need to explain or just give information.

Dial up the charm when you're:

Trying to persuade
For example in bids, advertising, opinion pieces, marketing materials including brochures, invitations, and internal communications like e-mails, intranet articles and announcements.

Here, use all the techniques to create charm. But use your common sense. Only use them when it feels absolutely right.

Restrict yourself to personal pronouns and writing with energy when you're:

Explaining and informing
For example in announcements and status letters, internal communications on sensitive subjects.

Headlines

(1/2)

Headlines are the first step to grabbing readers' attention. So they matter. And in our new brand design, they matter even more. You can use the principles from our tone of voice to help get them right.

Two steps to success
The keyline – grab the reader's attention.
The infoline – give a little more information.
The two work together. The first sets up expectations and the second brings them into focus.

How to use our tone of voice
In the keyline, *charm* dominates.
In the infoline, it's mostly about being *clear* and *convincing*.
(Though sometimes an aside will work.)

Using charm
Be personal, vary the rhythm – talking about *we* and *our* always works better than talking about ourselves as *UBS*.
Be intriguing – one-word keylines will make readers curious. Ask a question to add to the effect.
Be memorable – can you paint a picture of the value the reader gets? Tap into a universal truth – it's a chance to draw on the culture of your region with a phrase or image that resonates there.

Being clear
Keep it simple – to keep the word count down use verbs instead of nouns. And keep the verbs active.
Use everyday words and phrases – formal words are never helpful, but especially not in headlines.

Being convincing
Benefits, not processes – it's all about the value the reader will get from what we're describing, whether it's an event or an investment service. Don't name a product or service in the keyline, for example. Think about what it means for our clients. What will they be able to do?
Evidence, not adjectives – a fact will always have more impact than an adjective. Think about saying *we cover everything* rather than *comprehensive service*.

Punctuation
Our headlines have two levels. The meaning of the keyline is usually so obvious that you don't need punctuation, except a question mark. Two exceptions, though. In one-word keylines, a period can add emphasis and impact. Like this:

keyline Definitive.
infoline All the facts on alternative investments

If the infoline has more than one sentence, end each with a period.

Headlines

Some examples

So this:	Becomes this:
Wealth Management UK Protecting and managing wealth is at the heart of what we do	Green fingers Protecting your wealth and helping it grow. It's what we do.
UBS Investment Bank Being client-centric is in our DNA	Of course Investment banking that puts you first.
UBS Investment Mandates All of our financial competence in one optimized solution for you	Together Our investment know-how, your way.

Bringing it all together

Examples

Asset management

[Strategic Investment Advisory web page]

Before:

Strategic Investment Advisory
Within our Global Investment Solutions group we have recently created a distinct unit called Strategic Investment Advisory (SIA). SIA provides clients with a range of services including investment policy development, total portfolio construction and management incorporating alternative assets, risk management services, global tactical asset allocation, and multi-manager research and portfolio construction. Additionally, SIA provides Asset Liability Management and Fiduciary Management for pension funds.

SIA draws upon a broad range of professional experience in the SIA team and beyond, including former consultants and actuaries, former pension plan sponsors or trustees, research analysts, risk managers, derivatives specialists and individuals from a variety of other professional and academic backgrounds.

We provide advice to a range of institutional clients including pension funds, endowments, insurance companies, friendly societies, charities and family offices.

After:

Strategic investment advice
Investment specialists need specialist advice. We have a team to make sure you get it. We help you develop investment policy, build your portfolio and manage it. We've put the team together to advise clients from pension funds, endowments and insurance companies to friendly societies, charities and family offices.

The service includes:
- alternative assets
- risk management
- tactical asset allocation
- multi-manager portfolios.

And for pension funds, the team offers asset liability management and fiduciary management. We call it Strategic Investment Advisory (SIA).

Many specialties make for deeper insights. So the team includes former consultants and actuaries, pension plan sponsors and trustees, research managers and derivatives specialists. (Not to mention others from beyond finance.)

Asset management (2/2)

What's changed

Clear
- The main point is what the team offers, so we've put that first.
- Bullet points make it easier to see what the service is at a glance
- The original had formal-sounding words and phrases, like *within, provides, draws upon, additionally* and *a variety of*. Getting rid of them makes the writing sound more human.
- There were some long sentences in the original – one was 43 words. Now the longest sentence is 25 words.

Convincing
- Readers don't want to know about our internal team structure or the new team's name (at least not right away). They'll be more interested in what they might get. So we've changed the opening to emphasize the main point.

…with Charm
- The opening line makes the main point using an observation. That's memorable.
- The original talked about *we*, but we've made the new version do that more often.
- We've mixed up the sentence lengths to vary the rhythm.
- We've turned the diversity of the team into an aside. It helps suggest this is what gives them an edge.

HR internal communications

(1/3)

[Individual development steps intranet page]

Before:

It is essential that you identify your mid- to long-term career aspirations and think about how you plan to achieve them. The resources for individual development give you a framework to capture your aspirations and track related goals and actions. Central to the framework is the development discussion with your manager. Start preparing your discussion points and potential development actions as a first step.

After:

Where do you see yourself in three years? What about five?
We have ways to help you decide. The main one is talking to your manager about your development. So make sure you take some time to prepare for that conversation. Start by pondering these questions: What do you want to do? What are the steps from where you are now? What goals can you set along the way? What skills will you need to build?

What's changed

Clear
- Words like *resources* and *framework* make something exciting (your career) sound bureaucratic, so we've done without them. Likewise formal words such as *identify*, *aspirations* and *actions*.

Convincing
- The original was more about process than aspirations. The new version paints a picture of those aspirations by asking the reader where they want to be in three and five years instead of talking about mid- and long-term aspirations.

…with Charm
- The new version uses questions to make the whole subject of personal development more intriguing.
- In the original, the sentences were all around the same length. In the new version they vary. So it's a more enjoyable read.

HR internal communications

(2/3)

[Coffee corners intranet item]

Before:

Coffee Corners nurture integrity by creating a closer link between management and employees, motivating staff to challenge the way decisions are made. Break-through ideas have been known to arise inside the four walls of a session. In essence: Coffee Corners embody UBS behaviors in a changing culture of communication revolving around openness and dialogue. And they ensure all employees have a mutual understanding of the vision for Group Technology and where it is heading.

After:

We've seen people come up with great ideas at Group Technology 'Coffee Corners'. They're a chance to get together and share thoughts, challenge how decisions are made, and understand and influence plans for the future.

They characterize the way we want to work, making sure we're all open and honest with each other. (Wherever you are on the org chart.)

What's changed

Clear
- We've broken the information into two paragraphs to make it easier to digest.
- We've used everyday phrases like *the way we want to work*, rather than *UBS behaviors*, and *making sure* instead of *ensure*.

Convincing
- The original talked about how Coffee Corners work first. We've put the benefit – great ideas – at the start, before the *how*.

…with Charm
- In the original, the sentences were all a similar length and quite long. We've varied the length of sentences to give it a lively rhythm.
- We've talked about *we* instead of *UBS* all the way through to make it personal.
- Everyone knows about org charts, so we used them as a shorthand way to say Coffee Corners are for everyone. And put it in brackets as an aside.

HR internal communications

(3/3)

Before:

Prepare for PMM
Finalize your objectives before the system closes on Friday 7 November, to prepare for the year-end performance assessment process (PMM) which launches on Monday 17 November.

In preparation, all employees are requested to **enter the PMM tool before 7 November to ensure that their objectives are accurate and complete,** taking into account any changes in responsibilities or business priorities that have occurred during the year. Additionally, if a role or manager change has occurred in 2014, employees should check their profile in PMM and contact Human Resources if it is inaccurate.

Any changes to objectives must be formally agreed with your manager. Please ensure that you and your manager have both viewed your objective setting form and clicked the "agree all" button.

The PMM tool will close on 7 November for important system updates, therefore no changes or agreement to objectives can be made after this date.

After:

To make sure you're all set for your performance assessment, confirm your details in the system no later than Friday 7 November

You won't be able to make any changes after 7 November, so check the information in the system as soon as possible.

The year-end performance assessment process (PMM) starts on Monday 17 November and your profile and objectives must be correct.

Check your profile
Make sure information about your role and your manager is up to date. If it isn't, get in touch with HR.

Check your objectives are accurate and complete
If they've changed, update the information. And make sure you agree any changes with your manager. (Don't click 'agree all' without their okay.)

What's changed

Clear
- We put the main point in the heading and reinforced the point in the first sentence.
- We used helpful subheadings so people could see what they needed to do at a glance.
- We've made passive phrases *objectives must be formally agreed* active *You'll need to agree any changes with your manager*.

…with Charm
- We've made it personal, using *you* throughout.
- We've mixed up sentence lengths.
- We've added an aside: a lighthearted reminder not to save changes without agreeing them.

Investment banking

[Equities landing page]

Before:

Equities – leading the market
UBS is known worldwide for its leadership in the equities field. From distribution, trading, finance and clearing of cash equity and equity-linked products, to structuring, origination and distribution of new equity and equity-linked issues, we bring our clients the benefits of innovative thinking, superb execution and outstanding client service across the full product spectrum.

Our research coverage of companies, industry sectors, geographical markets and macroeconomic trends is award-winning. With market-leading trading execution for single stock and portfolio trading, UBS provides capital commitment, full service and block trading, advanced electronic trading strategies and tools, state-of-the-art analytics and value-enhancing commission management services. We continue to invest in the best technology to provide service that's fast, robust, reliable and efficient.

Our success in managing large and complex capital markets transactions is the product of a powerful global distribution network. We are a leading global distributor of block trades, rights offerings, IPOs, and hybrid and convertible issues to institutional and private clients in every market.

Demonstrating our ability to support our clients throughout the market cycle, our innovative, customized risk management solutions for clients include products whose returns are linked to equities or equity indices, and derivative products linked to hedge funds, mutual funds, real estate and commodity indices.

After:

Equities – everything in one place
Raising capital using equities? We can help. (Even if your ideas are complicated.)

We offer the full range of services for cash equity and equity-linked products, including:
- distribution
- trading
- finance
- clearing.

And we structure, originate and distribute new equity and equity-linked issues.

Managing large and complex capital market transactions
You can rely on our relationships and global distribution network to reach institutional and private clients in every market. For block trades, rights offerings, IPOs, hybrid and convertible issues.

Managing risk
We'll work with you to come up with strategies that match your attitude to risk. (And the market cycle, of course.) We base them on:
- products with returns linked to equities or equity indices
- derivative products linked to hedge funds, mutual funds, real estate and commodity indices.

How we do it
We've won awards for our research on companies, industry sectors, geographical markets and macroeconomic trends.

We use our expertise and experience to devise strategies. These strengths matter when the complexity of your needs calls for innovation.

And we're always investing in our technology. That means you can expect services and execution to be fast and reliable.

Our services in detail:
- single stock, portfolio and block trading
- full service
- advanced electronic trading strategies and tools
- analytics
- commission management services

Investment banking

(2/2)

What's changed

Clear
- We've reorganized the content to put the main point at the top and highlighted the benefits for clients.
- Bullet points make those long lists in long sentences easier to grasp.
- We've used subheadings to summarize the content. So anyone just glancing at the page would have a good idea what it says.

Convincing
- The original talks a lot about what UBS does; we've emphasized the benefits by saying *you can rely on…*
- We've taken out the adjectives we haven't got evidence for, like *market-leading, robust* and *state-of-the-art*.

…with Charm
- We've made it more personal by saying *we* and not *UBS*.
- Using pictures in the heading *all the services you need in one place* and the first sentence *in safe hands* brings home the confidence you have about the service you offer.
- We've included a tongue-in-cheek aside (*And the market cycle, of course.*).

Wealth management

(1/4)

[APAC] [Perspectives section of CEO column]

Before:

Delivering on our client promise encompasses all aspects of your experience with UBS, from receiving your much improved client statement to the key CIO predictions that have delivered good returns in 2013. US stocks are up over 26% since it was upgraded in January and, more recently, Eurozone stocks are up about 10% in the two months since CIO upgraded the region's equities market. In Fixed Income, our strong preference for US high-yield bonds has paid off as well, with the asset class returning almost 7% this year, while most other bond classes struggled to deliver positive returns.

After:

Every part of our relationship with you matters to us. From smaller details like giving you a statement that's much easier to read, to our main focus: making recommendations that bring you the best returns.

A glance at 2013 shows our predictions paying off:

- US stocks up over 26% since CIO's January upgrade
- Eurozone equities up by around 10% two months on from CIO's upgrade
- US high-yield bonds – our preference in Fixed Income investments – up 7%, while most other bonds struggled

What's changed

Clear

- Bullet points make the statistics stand out.
- The original had formal words like *encompasses* and *aspects*. And business buzzwords like *deliver* – we've changed them to more everyday words.

Convincing

- We've made the first sentence more meaningful, concrete. Before, the opening phrase was abstract *Delivering on our client promise encompasses all aspects of your experience with UBS*.
- We've changed the adjective *much-improved* to say what's better about the new statement.

…with Charm

- The original used *you* but not *we* or *us* so we've changed that to make the tone consistent.

Wealth management

[APAC] [Letter to individual client about closing their account]

Before:

Dear Valued Client,
We acknowledge receipt of your instruction dated «mf_Closure_Welcome_Sign_Date» to close your UBS Active Portfolio Advisory Agreement with the firm. The request is already being attended to.

Please note that as a result of this, the corresponding Portfolio Risk Profile previously selected for the Investment Strategy of your Active Portfolio Advisory account will no longer apply. However, the General Account Agreement shall remain valid and all other account(s) shall remain operative notwithstanding the closure of the Active Portfolio Advisory service agreement.

While we certainly hope you have enjoyed your experience as a client of our Active Portfolio Advisory service and have benefited from our proactive advice and portfolio monitoring, we respect your decision to cancel the service.

We value our relationship with you and always welcome your feedback on how we can serve you better. Should you have any questions, please contact your Client Advisor who will work together with you to define the best solution for you.

After:

Closing your Active Portfolio Advisory account [Account_Number]

Dear [name],

We've received your request to close your Active Portfolio Advisory account on [date]. We've put things in motion and we'll let you know when the account is closed. This won't affect any other accounts you have with us.

We're sorry you're closing the account and we'd be interested to hear how you felt about our service. Please get in touch with your Client Advisor [name], on [contact details: phone number and e-mail address] if you'd like to share your thoughts and find out if we can help with any of your investment plans.

We look forward to hearing from you.

Wealth management

What's changed

Clear

- The original letter used formal words like *acknowledge receipt* and *notwithstanding*. We've used everyday words instead.
- We've kept things simple – there was a long-winded sentence explaining that closing this account wouldn't affect anything else.
- There were lots of passive sentences like *The request is already being attended to*. We've made them active: *We've put things in motion and we'll let you know when the account's closed*.

Convincing

- We've only included what was necessary in the letter – we've left out the paragraph about respecting the client's decision.

Wealth management

[US] [Credit card brochure]

Before:

Access cash without the fees
What makes our card different from most other credit cards is that you can access cash at ATMs and banks worldwide without paying finance charges or cash advance fees. With the unique CashConnect feature, your cash advances are automatically repaid each business day from your UBS Resource Management Account (RMA), provided you have sufficient funds available.

You'll also receive an unlimited number of ATM fee rebates in the US (up to $3 per transaction).

After:

Get cash with your credit card. Without paying for the privilege.
Use our credit card at ATMs and banks worldwide to get cash – and you won't pay finance charges or cash advance fees. We use the money in your UBS Resource Management Account to repay any cash you've taken out with your card each business day (as long as there's enough in your account).

And we'll pay back US ATM fees – up to $3 a time.

We call it CashConnect. And it's unique. (We've checked.)

What's changed

Clear
- We've got rid of formal and technical-sounding words like *receive, fee rebates* and *access,* and talked about *getting cash* and *paying back* fees, which sounds more like we would if we explained this *face to face*.

Convincing
- The rewrite focuses on benefits for the customer – we've deleted *What makes our card different* and put the name of the feature at the end.
- We've claimed it's unique, because we know it is.

...with Charm
- We've mixed up the sentence lengths to make it a more enjoyable read.
- To make it memorable, we've made an observation. By saying *without paying for the privilege* we're showing that we understand people expect to have to pay for convenience.
- The aside at the end shows we're not taking ourselves too seriously and can be lighthearted.

Dialling up the charm

Here's an example rewritten in a clear and convincing way, with a little bit of charm.
Then we've written it again, with more charm, so you can see the difference.

Before:

Create more opportunities by unlocking the full potential of your wealth
If you think about the full value of your wealth, you may not always realize its full potential. By having a UBS Credit Line in place, you'll have immediate access to the funds you need to make opportunities happen for you, your business and your family. By tapping into the borrowing power of your eligible UBS assets, you'll have the liquidity you need today and still be able to pursue your long-term investment strategy.

A strategic way to pay your taxes, build your business and more
You can use a UBS Credit Line to fund this year's tax payment, take advantage of a time-sensitive real estate opportunity, or build an addition to your home. Or if you prefer, you can use it to help your son or daughter buy their first home by using it for a down payment, or you can assist a grandchild with college tuition. If you're a business owner, it frees up your cash flow to help you fund business expansion or purchase inventory.

Some charm:

Unlock your wealth
Tap into the power of your assets right away with a UBS Credit Line.

You can borrow against what you've got invested with us, without affecting your long-term plans for your wealth.
You decide what to do with it. You could:
- pay a tax bill
- take advantage of a real estate opportunity
- extend your home
- help your son or daughter buy a home
- pay a grandchild's college fees.

If you run your own business, you could:
- expand
- buy inventory.

Dialling up the charm

(2/3)

What's changed

Clear and convincing

- We've put the main point first and right away. (In the original, you could delete the first sentence and not miss it.)
- The original had some formal words like *pursue*, *purchase* and *assist*. We've used everyday language.
- Bullet points make the options stand out.
- We've kept it as simple as possible – so we've cut some copy that was very similar: *you'll have immediate access* and *you'll have the liquidity*.
- We've only said what we needed to. We've left out phrases like *Or if you prefer* and *by using it for a down payment* so the benefits are loud and clear.

...with Charm

- We've kept it personal, using *we* and *you*.

But we could go further.

Dialling up the charm

Some charm:

Unlock your wealth
Tap into the power of your assets any time with a UBS Credit Line. You can borrow against what you've got invested with us, without affecting your long-term plans for your wealth.

You decide what to do with it. You could:
- pay a tax bill
- take advantage of a real estate opportunity
- extend your home
- help your son or daughter buy a home
- pay a grandchild's college fees.

If you run your own business, you could:
- expand
- buy inventory.

More charm:

What if you could have your cake and eat it too?
Tap into the power of your assets with a UBS Credit Line. Right away. We can give you a loan against what you've got invested with us, and it doesn't affect your long-term plans for your wealth.

Do you want to:
- move fast on a real estate opportunity?
- extend your home?
- help the family with property or college costs?
- expand your business?

It's up to you. (You can even use it to pay a tax bill.)

What's changed now

...with even more Charm
- We've included questions to make it intriguing – including the title.
- We've introduced a more dynamic rhythm with a short sentence in the first line.
- To make it even more memorable and intriguing, we've used an aside. This also reflects the fact that sometimes we need money for mundane things.
- The headline is a well-known phrase that paints a picture.

Resources

Extra help

Checklist

A step-by-step guide to being clear and convincing – and adding charm when you need to.

Planning

1. Who's the audience?
   The first step to working out what to include and how much charm to use. What would they want to read?
2. What's the main point?
   Write that down – you've got your first sentence.
3. What questions would your audience have about that main point?
   Use those to come up with subheadings. And put them in order of priority.
4. Do you have the content you need?
   Make sure you've got the facts that will answer your readers' questions and evidence to back up any claims.

Writing

5. Are you writing about benefits instead of processes?
   Try to begin your sentences with You *as much as possible to start with. It will help you think along the right lines.*
6. Do you really need every adjective?
   Have you got any evidence? Can you write about that to show what you mean?
7. Are your sentences short enough?
   Try writing in short sentences, then join some of them together. That's easier than untangling long ones. Remember 20–30 words max. Mix them up.

Polishing

8. Is everything you've said getting the main point across?
   Test every paragraph and be brave – cut anything that doesn't help your reader get the message.
9. Does it sound human?
   Not chatty or casual. Just how you would if you were talking to your reader one-to-one.
10. Have you used the right amount of charm?
    Look back at the brief. If you're aiming to get a reaction, look for opportunities to ask questions, paint pictures or add an aside. If you're writing about something very serious or sensitive – bad news for example – think again about whether you're being too lighthearted.

Extra tip: Planning
Double-check your plan. Do you need all the things you've listed? Maybe some at the bottom aren't really necessary.

Extra tip: Writing
You might not notice you've used jargon or formal words as you're going along. So read with that in mind. Change any you spot.

Extra tip: Polishing
Does your audience speak English as a first language? Will they understand all the phrases you've used? If in doubt, ask someone to check.

Briefing writers

Good writing starts with a good brief. Without it, the writer is working in the dark and may go off down the wrong track.

To get what you want from a piece of writing, make sure the writer understands who they're writing for, why we're writing, and how we want to sound. This is important whether the writer is an employee, a freelancer or an agency.

Once you've produced a brief, run through it with the writer to check everyone understands and agrees on the content and format.

The basics

Tell them:

- What kind of writing it is
  E-mail, letter, webpage, brochure, ad? Do you know the word count?
- Who the reader is
  Including how much they know about the topic and if English is their first language.
- What they need to know, feel and do
  And which of them is most important.
- Where the content is coming from
  Is the writer researching independently? Are they interviewing people? Are they analyzing data? All three?
- What we want to achieve
  Are we persuading people to do something? Are we making sure they know about a new regulation?

The practicalities

- How the writing relates to anything else the reader has seen from us
  Do the writers need to refer to anything or follow a specific format?
- The timetable
  When do you need the first draft? How much time is there for feedback and rewriting?

Our tone of voice

For in-house writers

- Check they know about it and how to use it. Especially when and how to use charm.
- Suggest they use the checklist.
- Tell them about training: e-Learning, UBS Connections.

For external writers

- Introduce the tone of voice using 'In short'.
- Make sure they have the full guidelines.
- Show them the section about adding more charm if the work calls for it.
- Tell them about the checklist.

Giving feedback

(1/2)

Writing: everyone has an opinion about it. So giving feedback can get complicated, especially when several of us are reviewing and signing off. Even if you're doing it all yourself, you might not know where to start.

Remember, the question isn't *do you like it?* It's
- *does it follow the brief?*
- *is it clear and convincing, with charm?*

Here are two steps to giving unambiguous and objective feedback.

Step one: check the brief.
That tells you:
- what kind of writing it is – e-mail, letter, webpage, brochure, ad
- who the reader is
- what they need to know, feel and do
- what we're trying to achieve
- how the writing relates to anything else the reader has seen from us

And it means you're starting from the same place as the writer.

If you wrote the brief, go straight to the next step.

Giving feedback

(2/2)

Step two: break feedback into these categories

Content – what we're saying
Structure – the order we're saying it in
Tone – how we're saying it

Cover all the points under each section (below) and the writer will hear feedback that's objective and helpful, not personal opinion. And you'll make sure it's following our guidelines. That lets you take a step back from it instead of giving feedback line by line from the start. And you'll separate comments on detail from overall, big picture thoughts.

Here's what to look for:

Content
Does it answer any questions the reader might have?

- Is all the key information there?
- Is it relevant to the audience?
- Is it clear what we want readers to know, feel and do?
- Are the facts right?
- Is the information specific enough?
- Does it make the benefits clear (not just the features and process)?
- Is there jargon? Do we need to explain it?
- If we make any claims, can we back them up with evidence?

Structure
Is it clear at a glance what the piece is about? Can you read all the sentences in one breath?

- Is the main point first? Do we get to it quickly?
- Is it broken up with enough subheadings?
- Are there any sentences over 30 words – or paragraphs with more than one topic?

Tone
Does this sound like someone speaking face-to-face?

- Does it use everyday words and phrases?
- Are the sentences mostly the same length? If they are, there's not enough energy.
- Is our opinion clear? Do we get it across confidently?
- Do we paint a picture, so it's easy to imagine what we're describing?
- Would an aside liven it up? Or are there too many?

Where to get help

Whether you're writing or reviewing communications, you're not on your own. There's training and e-learning you can sign up for. And the *Language Matters* platform on UBS Connections – we'll all benefit by sharing ideas and writing examples.

There are specific guides for social media, writing for the web, writing persuasively, letters and e-mails, using stories and writing for legal.

For guidance on our house style, go to our language guidelines at: goto/language.

If you have any questions about writing, ask the Brand Strategy team at sh-branding@ubs.com